Safe Zone Estimation For Autonomous Vehicles

Sreenivasa Chakravarthi Sangapu
Department of Computer Science and Engineering
Amrita Vishwa Vidyapeetham
Chennai, India
ss_chakravarthi@ch.amrita.edu

Rudraraju Vignesh Varma
Department of Computer Science and Engineering
Amrita Vishwa Vidyapeetham
Chennai, India
vigneshvarmarudra123@gmail.com

Pulusu Venkata Naga Varshith
Department of Computer Science and Engineering
Amrita Vishwa Vidyapeetham
Chennai, India
varshithnagaa34@gmail.com

***Abstract*—With the rise of autonomous vehicles in our transport systems, the development of intelligent systems for automated collision avoidance and advanced navigation in complex traffic situations is vital. This paper presents the implementation of a Safe Zone Estimation System, assessing via real-time traffic systems and estimations of the safe operating area for autonomous vehicles. Real-time traffic simulator SUMO, and Tkinter for visualizing safe zones, as well as, visual interface for hazardous traffic situations are integrated. A safe distance is calculated using a distance calculation, vehicle speed, reaction time, and road friction are considered, while a kinematic set of equations verifies if the adjacent cars infringe the triangular safety zone using a geometric shape. A passage decision-aiding warning is produced if a boundary is breached. The proposed system increases the safety of the driver or control system by providing advanced situational awareness and can be integrated into the Safe Autonomous Vehicle Driving Safety Framework while retaining its functionality.**

***Index Terms*—Autonomous Driving, Safety Zone Estimation, Collision Avoidance, SUMO, Visual Tkinter Applications, Traffic Safety, Spatial Analysis, Vehicle Detection Systems, Intelligent Traffic Systems.**

I. INTRODUCTION

Autonomous Vehicles (AVs) are anticipated as one of the most groundbreaking innovations in the world of transportation. Their transformative capabilities include fostering safety, traffic efficiency, and reducing human error. With the integration of advanced perception, communication, and control technologies, AVs will likely sidestep most of the road accidents attributed to slow human reaction, poor judgment of safe distances, and inattention. However, despite the rapid pace of technological innovations, the resolution of safe autonomous driving still crucially depends on the ability to sense the real-world environment and to keep safe zones around the vehicle in operation.

Safe zone estimation techniques are one of the most important concepts in addressing this challenge. A safe zone can be defined as the spatial region surrounding a vehicle in which no collisions should occur if normal driving and braking dynamics are retained. Considerable contributions include vehicle speed, braking distance, friction coefficient, and driver or system reaction time. Shifting the attention to the traditional advanced driver-assistance systems (ADAS) which are typically reactive - they will release warnings or take evasive measures only when a target is about to be struck or a crash is unavoidable. This is in contrast to proactive safe zone estimation systems which will continuously analyze the dynamic traffic environment, predict conflicts, and issue warnings in advance, thereby increasing both safety as well as decision-making efficiency.

The development of Intelligent Transportation Systems (ITS) together with the principles of Industry 4.0 has made it possible to acquire and process data in real-time and to communicate data between vehicles and infrastructure. This technological development makes it possible for Autonomous Vehicles (AVs) to perceive their surroundings, communicate with other vehicles, and make independent driving decisions. One of the most interesting and challenging problems in the Intelligent Transportation Systems world is the estimation of safe distance and applicable driving rules in real-time, complex, and dynamic environments of varying traffic conditions. Many of these vehicle-centric solutions don't provide real-time, intuitive, decision-aiding visual feedback, and to the best of my knowledge, no solution exists that provides safety estimation within a functional vehicle scheduling system.

To fill these voids, this research has developed a Safe Zone Estimation System, which leverages real-time simulation with SUMO (Simulation of Urban Mobility) and TraCI, and a Tkinter GUI for dynamic visualization of safe zones and a user's customizable simulation environment. The system provides a dynamic safe radius by employing physics-based models that factor in a vehicle's speed, reaction time and braking capabilities. It also predicts a vehicle's safety triangles to track surrounding vehicles, intervening intrusively and alerting their operator of a traffic violation that breaches their safety margin.

This work has contributed to the body of knowledge in the following ways:

1. A dynamic safe zone estimation framework based on the physics of operation of AVs.
2. Real-time safe zone visualization and a vehicle incursion detection system.
3. SUMO traffic simulation integrated with a simplified and interactive visualization module.
4. A predictive approach to AV safety within spatially predictive situational awareness as opposed to the conventional reactive approach.

This framework has been developed as a research-centric system for the evaluation and examination of safety methodologies within autonomous driving. While this iteration employs simulation data, the approach can incorporate real-world environments via the integration of sensors, data, and networks. Essentially, estimation of safe zones will become the foundation upon which confidence in operating, reliability, and safety in future autonomous cars can be established.

With autonomous vehicle deployment ongoing at an increasing pace in various environments, the ability to sense and respond to richer traffic scenarios in real-time has increasingly been a focus. Beyond merely collision avoidance, secure and stable navigation requires predictive modeling of surrounding space under a broad set of operating conditions. Safe zone estimation is also vital in communicating this spatial recognition, particularly where the reaction time is short and the error window is small.

Another key consideration to this investigation is the increased heterogeneity of road environments. Autonomous cars will need to coexist with human-driven automobiles, bicycles, and pedestrians who are not necessarily predictable in their behavior. Traditional rule-based safety mechanisms can tackle uncertainty caused by human behavior, sudden lane change, unreliable braking, or non-nominal pedestrian motion only to a limited extent. Adaptive approaches to safe zone calculation, on the other hand, allow the car to recalculate its buffer of safety continuously, offering greater real-world robustness.

In addition, conditions of environmental variability such as slippery or icy pavement, poor visibility, road curves, and variable friction coefficients significantly influence reaction ability as well as stopping distances. Static safety boundaries are a failure in such a scenario, and hence dynamic, physics-based determination of safe regions is extremely important. Such a flexible safety system can be implemented to stabilize the autonomous vehicles and reduce collision risk even under the worst road conditions.

Another compelling driving force is the shift towards cooperative mobility systems. Innovative connected vehicle technologies, such as Vehicle-to-Vehicle (V2V) and Vehicle-to-Infrastructure (V2I) communication, allow vehicles to share trajectory, speed, and intention data. When safe zone estimation is integrated into this cooperative system, vehicles are able to respond to oncoming intrusions earlier than onboard sensors would even by themselves. This anticipatory response smooths merging, facilitates safer lane changing, and collision-free passage of intersections—particularly in metropolitan and highway speed environments.

Along with this, merging safe zone estimation with simulation platforms such as SUMO, CARLA, and VISSIM makes it easy to provide a suitable environment for testing safety algorithms at scale. The simulators replicate realistic driving conditions and traffic behaviors, allowing researchers to observe edge cases, worst-case scenarios, and multi-agent interactions without risking physical vehicles. Such insights can be utilized to inform real-world deployment of autonomous safety systems.

Even more pertinent is the use of explainability and visualization in safety-critical systems. Black-box decision-making has a tendency to hide decision-making, which is harmful to trust, regulation, and debugging. Visualizing the safe zone surrounding a car, on the other hand, provides understandable, human-readable feedback. This serves developers and regulators well but also helps human drivers of semi-autonomous systems to understand vehicle behavior and respond accordingly when intervention is required.

Finally, the growing emphasis on zero-fatality transportation goals—such as those promoted by Vision Zero initiatives worldwide—highlights the need for reliable, preventive measures of safety. Safe zone estimation provides these functions directly by shifting the model of safety from reaction to anticipation. Instead of waiting idly while an unsafe situation develops, the vehicle detects probable conflict and reacts before it, ultimately reducing crash rates and improving roadway safety for all.

In summary, the application of dynamic, adaptive, and interpretable safe zone estimation systems is not only a technological innovation but an essential requirement for the large-scale deployment of autonomous vehicles. These systems can provide an anticipatory safety umbrella that considers vehicle dynamics and environmental uncertainty, and are the foundation on which safe and intelligent mobility is constructed.

II. Literature Survey

Numerous research studies that use different methods such as physics-based methods, probabilistic methods, and perception-based systems have been done on estimating safe zone and avoiding collisions for autonomous vehicles. Most of the existing studies performed real-time risk assessment for predicting and avoiding collisions. However, the studies tend to focus on global traffic management rather than localized vehicle-centric safety visualization.

Physics-based methods provide deterministic and interpretable results by calculating safe distance using kinematic and energy equations with factors such as speed, reaction time, and braking. However, they are less useful in high uncertainty of parameters. In probabilistic headway methods, conflict likelihood is estimated using traffic flow parameters and critical gaps. These methods efficiently capture stochastic arrival patterns, however, they do not have geometric intrusion analysis. Perception systems using on-board sensors, such as LiDAR and radar, provide accurate real-time detection, but are dependent on sensor reliability and are liable to be reactive.

Safety algorithms are commonly validated using simulation platforms like SUMO, VISSIM, and CARLA. These allow us for testing in environments which are simulated, but the majority of research supposes ideal sensing conditions and ignores noise, latency, or mixed traffic interactions. Some methods, such as Crossing Risk Degree (CRD), work by looking at how much energy a potential collision might involve and how likely it is to happen. This helps decide which vehicle should move through an intersection first. But these methods are used mostly to control traffic among the entire network and do not care about what is happening around a single particular system.

Identified Research Gaps

1. No vehicle-centric safe space visualization exists for aiding real-time decision-making.

2. Assumptions regarding ideal sensing and communication are overly trusting.

3. The integration of safety through physics is little and imbalanced with intuitive graphics.

4. There are few lightweight structures that combine simulation and visualization for quick testing.

Contribution of the Present Work

1. This study proposes a physics and geometry-based safe zone estimation model using SUMO and TraCI for real-time simulation and Tkinter for dynamic visualization. Unlike conventional reactive methods, the proposed framework:

2. Defines dynamic safe radii and triangular monitoring zones.

3. Detects and visualizes intrusions by neighboring vehicles.

4. For development and research purposes, supplies a lightweight, interpretable and extensible platform.

A comparative summary of existing approaches is presented in Table I.

1) Cooperative and Connected Vehicle Safety Frameworks: With the development of connected vehicle technology, especially Vehicle-to-Vehicle (V2V) and Vehicle-to-Infrastructure (V2I) communication, the need for cooperative collision avoidance techniques is growing. Different from the conventional strategies, connected vehicles communicate and share data on speed, position, and projected paths. This information relies on more advanced techniques to predict conflicts and potential collisions.

These frameworks enhance safety at intersections and facilitate coordinated decision-making among multiple agents, thereby reducing uncertainty in decision-making during ambiguous and complex high-demand situations.

Limitations: Real-time implementation of most cooperative collision avoidance strategies is expensive and complicated to execute. Moreover, the absence of near vehicle safe zone visualization, coupled with high demand on low latency and high reliable communication network to make cooperative collision avoidance techniques possible, additive to the increased demand to make techniques real-time, are marked as greatest limitations.

2) Hybrid and Multi-Layered Safety Models: One of the trends that are beginning to be noticed is the use of hybrid frameworks that combine different methods. For example, pairing machine learning methods that are adaptable with other frameworks that are based on the more rigid and reliable physics of a system. This multi-layering enables a hybrid system to exploit the better, more reliable, and versatile approaches to improving the system's robustness.

A good example of this is a hybrid system that is based on physics approaches to safe-zone calculations and uses probabilistic methods and machine learning approaches to adjust the system dynamically. These systems are able to manage complex and variable traffic systems more efficiently than single-model approaches.

Disadvantages: More complex hybrid systems can sometimes be inappropriate in disposable, real-time, inexpensive, and lightweight implementations.

A. Adaptive Modeling of Environmental Conditions and Context-Aware Safety

Another expanding area of research pertains to context-aware estimation of safe zones where spatial factors such as road curvature, friction coefficient of the road and weather, illumination, and pedestrian traffic are included in the consideration.

Such factors provide the basis for more adaptive safe zones, that are context-dependent and for more realistic safety margins that approximate to the prevailing conditions of the environment.

Models of this sort are complicated and in certain contexts, such as severe weather, they can pose the risk of failure. Enhanced safety margins also create the challenge of more complicated sensor fusion.

1) Predictive Risk Assessment and Driver Intention Modeling: New research has emphasized the use of predictive risk modeling for expecting dangerous situations prior to their occurrence. In contrast to reactive collision avoidance, predictive methods utilize trajectory prediction, estimation of driver intentions, and motion forecasting of other vehicles in proximity. Through examination of speed, acceleration, turn signals, and past trends, predictive models make an effort to estimate forthcoming conflicts a few seconds ahead.

These methodologies normally employ Bayesian networks, Markov Decision Processes, or time-to-collision (TTC) measurements to estimate future states. When coupled with safe zone estimation, predictive risk models have the potential to enlarge the temporal horizon of collision avoidance systems, providing autonomous and human drivers with a longer time window to respond.

Limitations: These models depend on correct and up-to-date perception data. They are also sensitive to environmental uncertainty (e.g., occlusions or sensor dropouts), and could become computationally intensive for real-time deployment on embedded vehicle platforms.

2) Digital Twins and Simulation-Driven Safety Validation: Another research area on the horizon contains of applying digital twin platforms for simulating autonomous driving safety systems in realistic yet controlled virtual environments. Under such systems, each aspect of the car and the environment is reflected in a high-fidelity simulation platform, enabling researchers to test various traffic patterns and weather conditions without physical hazard.

For estimation of safe zones, digital twins enable:

a. Controlled manipulation of road topology, traffic volume, and environmental conditions.

b. Testing the resilience of safe zone algorithms in terms of unexpected traffic flow.

c. Integrating with real-time monitoring systems to assess how zone breaches are identified and addressed.

TABLE I
SUMMARY OF EXISTING STUDIES ON COLLISION AVOIDANCE AND SAFE ZONE ESTIMATION APPROACHES

Author (Year)	Method	Pros	Cons	Research Gap
Shen et al. (2025)	CRD energy-probability model	Interpretable severity	Intersection-level focus	Lack of vehicle-level visualization
Liu & Sun (2023)	Headway models	Captures stochastic arrivals	Temporal only	No spatial intrusion
Krajzewicz et al. (2012)	SUMO microsimulation	Mature platform	Lacks GUI-level safety	Visualization pipeline
Kumar et al. (2019)	Sensor zone warnings	Real-time alerts	Hardware dependent	SUMO-based validation

d. Simulation software such as CARLA, SUMO, and VISSIM are typically used to develop these virtual environments.

Limitations: While potent for study, digital twins do not necessarily reflect the variability and randomness of actual conditions like sensor degradation, latency, or human variability.

3) Explainable and Interpretable Safety Models: One of the increasing challenges in autonomous vehicle safety research is the lack of interpretability for most machine learning–based safety systems. Complicated black-box models can make good predictions but tend not to explain the reason why a specific alert or maneuver was initiated.

Physics-based and geometry-based safe zone estimation systems, however, offer the benefit of being transparent and explainable. This fits with the trend of newer work in Explainable AI (XAI) for autonomous driving, which stresses:

- Providing human-understandable warnings,
- Rendering safety envelopes visible via visualization, and
- Offering traceable logic for regulatory and validation purposes.

Studies in this field indicate that interpretable models enhance driver trust, make debugging easier, and speed up certification of autonomous vehicle systems.

Limitations: Interpretable models are simpler to understand, but they can fall short of the adaptive flexibility of deep learning–based methods, especially in very dynamic traffic conditions.

4) Human–Vehicle Interaction and Trust in Safety Systems: In addition to technical performance, driver acceptance and trust are also key to the success of any safety system. Current research in human factors engineering investigates how visualization of safety zones and warning systems affect driving behavior. For instance, presenting safety envelopes on in-car displays can:

- Assist drivers in comprehending their vehicle's safety buffer boundary,
- Decrease overdependence on automation,
- Enhance reaction time when using shared-control driving modes.

Such studies blend principles of human–machine interaction (HMI) with autonomous safety solutions, such that safe zone estimation becomes not just a technical element but also an interface for communication between vehicle and driver.

Limitations: It is still not easy to design intuitive interfaces that function across demographics and driving styles, and too many or poorly defined warnings can lead to alert fatigue or distraction.

5) Cooperative Multi-Agent Safety and Swarm Behavior: One promising area for future safe zone research is cooperative safety structures wherein multiple vehicles exchange real-time safe zone and trajectory information through V2X communication. This creates a distributed safety network, and through it, vehicles can:

- Predict conflicts sooner than onboard sensors can alone,
- Coordinate maneuvers like merging, lane changing, or crossing intersections,
- Enhance overall traffic flow and reduce accidents.

Such multi-agent systems are inspired by swarm behavior and game theory, where local rule leads to global stability and safety.

Limitations: Such systems rely on low-latency, high-reliability communication networks, which cannot always be guaranteed. Privacy and security are also ongoing research issues.

B. Summary of Additional Research Directions

Literature exhibits some upcoming trends in addition to the conventional physics, probabilistic, and perception-based safety paradigms. Predictive risk estimation, digital twins, explainability, human–machine interaction, and cooperative multi-agent safety are redefining the next generation of autonomous safety paradigms.

By placing safe zone estimation in these changing scenarios, the system proposed here matches the direction of AV safety work today — not only prioritizing real-time collision avoidance but also transparency, adaptability, and coordination between vehicles and their surroundings.

III. WHY DO WE NEED THIS?

The explosive expansion of intelligent transportation systems and autonomous driving technology has created a paradigm shift in the manner in which vehicles engage with their world. Although tremendous advances have been made in perception, localization, and control algorithms, road safety is a crucial bottleneck. Far too many modern autonomous systems depend largely on reactive methods — like emergency braking and collision avoidance — which only act when a threat is already present. These systems, while helpful, cannot be enough in situations with high speed vehicles, errant pedestrian flows, poor visibility conditions, or mixed traffic.

The gap is addressed by the urgent necessity for proactive, continuous, and adaptive safety estimation systems that can give early warnings and situation awareness prior to the collision risk building up. It is here that the Safe Zone Estimation System comes into play. Rather than reacting only to emergencies, it establishes and sustains an actual-time protective buffer zone around the car by merging physics-based distance modeling with geometric intrusion detection. It dynamically adapts the safe zone in real-time speed, road friction, traffic density, and vehicle dynamics, giving both visual warning and actional safety margins.

A. Motivation and Importance

Based on many worldwide road safety research, most road crashes are due to poor vehicle spacing, sluggish response time, and environmental uncertainty. Even minor changes in reaction time or stopping ability are enough to cause serious crashes at modest speeds. This underlines the importance of:

1. Early detection of potential intrusion events instead of last-minute emergency maneuvers.
2. Dynamic safety modeling responsive to real driving situations (speed, friction, visibility).
3. Visualization systems that clearly convey risks to drivers and autonomous control units.
4. Flexible algorithms that can function well in urban, rural, and highway settings.

Unlike traditional safety systems integrated in autonomous vehicles, the framework presented here does not depend on black-box sensor fusion or sophisticated machine learning algorithms. Rather, it applies transparent, physics-based reasoning integrated with spatial geometry in order to supply interpretable and actionable safety margins.

The proposed Safe Zone Estimation System has the potential to be useful in various driving situations, each with their own unique safety issues.

B. Practical Need Across Real-World Scenarios

1) Urban Cross-Section:

Urban intersections remain difficult environments for drivers regardless of whether they are human or machine-automated. With the potential for:

- A large volume of pedestrians,
- Unpredictable lane changes,
- Traffic stops (which are uncoordinated), and
- Vehicles passing through the zone from opposing directions.

These environments can be collision hotspots. In such cases, the Safe Zone system can efficiently estimate and assign a Safe Zone with a focus on low or moderate vehicular speeds, and can decide to shrink or expand as traffic conditions allow. The system also has the capability to estimate triangular lateral detection zones which can provide a predetermined alert to pedestrians or motorists flagged as potential encroachment risks from lateral zones.

As shown in Fig. 1, urban cross-sections present highly dynamic environments requiring adaptive safe zone estimation.

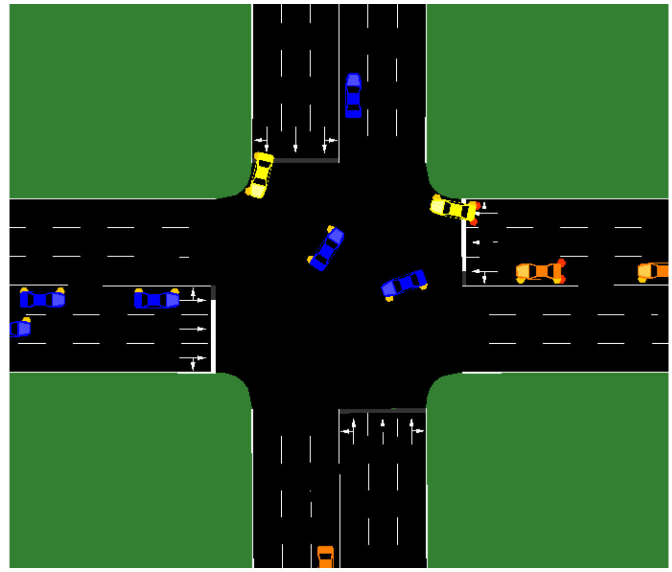

Fig. 1. Urban Cross-Section

2) Two-Lane Rural Roads:

Inadequate Infrastructure such as lane dividers increases the odds of head-on collisions on two-lane rural roads. Causes of head-on collisions in these situations include:

- Higher closing speeds during overtaking,
- Poor lighting conditions,
- Absence of automated traffic controls.

In these scenarios, the Safe Zone Estimation System relies on the projections of the lateral triangle to track the oncoming vehicles in the opposing lane. As the speed of the ego vehicle increases, the safety radius grows, allowing the driver to have more reaction time during evasive maneuvers.

When an oncoming vehicle crosses the critical intrusion line, the system warns the human driver or the control unit, thus practically eliminating the likelihood of head-on or sideswipe collisions, as shown in Fig. 2.

3) Multi-Lane Highways:

Multi-lane highways allow for high-speed driving along with frequent lane changes and close-following, which during any moment of inattention can have disastrous consequences. At these speeds, a reactive collision avoidance system may be inadequate.

The Safe Zone Estimation System addresses this problem by:

- Improving the system's longitudinal and lateral monitoring capabilities.
- Continuously monitoring vehicle speed and longitudinal spacing to enable timely evasive maneuvers during cut-in situations.

This functionality can be integrated with adaptive cruise control and lane-keeping systems to maintain safe following distances and prevent unsafe merging scenarios, as shown in Fig. 3.

4) Curved and Sloped Roads

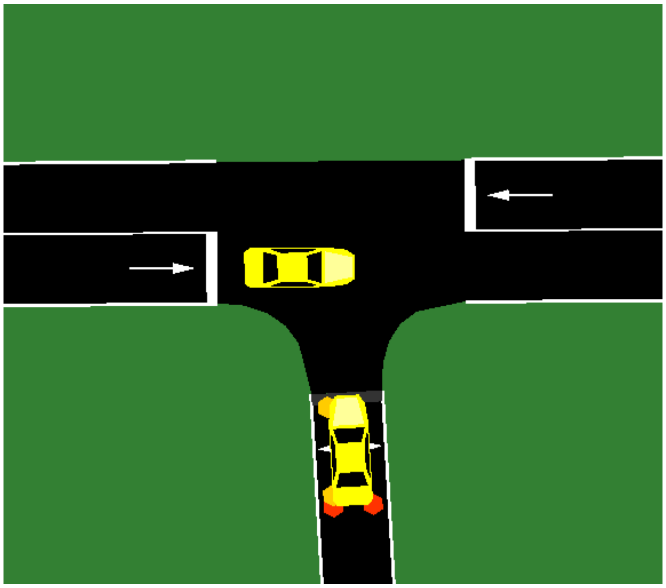

Fig. 2. Two-Lane Rural Roads

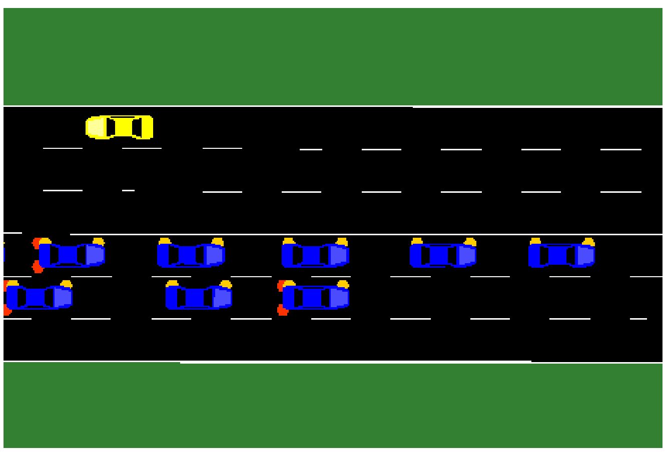

Fig. 3. Multi-Lane Highways

When it comes to complicated road systems, bends, gradients, and varying elevations invoke additional concerns, especially:

- Altered sight lines and gradients affecting road visibility.
- Stopping and deceleration distance increases.
- Vehicles may suddenly appear from blind curves.

With these concerns, the predicted braking distance considers the road incline and bend and applicable friction forces. The length of the reaction time is determinable and dynamically increased. Trimodal zones afford detection of vehicles that suddenly enter and blind approaches.

In these scenarios, it will help the most when considering the limitation of classical sensors on mountain roads, tunnels, and overtly tight bends.

5) Adverse Weather Conditions

In circumstances of rain, fog, snow, or gravel, the effects on road friction, visibility, and required stopping distance is considerable. Most road safety systems operate on the premise of ideal road conditions. This leads, particularly in the case of precipitation, to increasingly poor matrix conditions.

Safe Zone Estimation System allows for the safe zone radius to be altered under real or set friction coefficient conditions. For example, when:

- The road is dry ($\mu \approx 0.7$–0.8): the safe distance is shorter.
- The road is wet ($\mu \approx 0.4$–0.5): the safe distance is medium.
- The road is icy or extremely low friction ($\mu < 0.3$): a significant safe distance is added.

The system self-calibrating to the surrounding conditions helps to ensure that safety systems perform even under the most extreme conditions.

C. Impact and Relevance

The Safe Zone Estimation System carries with it implications beyond mere visualization:

Early warning layer for autonomous cars and advanced driver-assistance systems (ADAS).

Decreased collision probability in high-risk situations like intersections and highways.

Enhanced situational awareness for human drivers and AI-based control systems alike.

Synchronization with current tools such as SUMO (Simulation of Urban Mobility) and TraCI for testing and deployment.

In addition, the system can cater to future applications such as:

Sensor fusion with LiDAR, radar, and camera systems.

Cooperative safety frameworks based on V2X communication.

Integration with autonomous braking or path planning modules.

D. Summary

In summary, the Safe Zone Estimation project is necessary due to the increasing requirement for predictive safety frameworks in autonomous and semi-autonomous vehicles. Reactive systems today tend to respond too late, whereas sophisticated perception algorithms do not give interpretable feedback.

The intended system provides a physics-based, real-time, and vehicle-focused safety mechanism that is capable of adjusting to varied environments — from densely populated city streets to highways at high speeds and mountain roads with low visibility.

By closing the simulation-to-reality gap, this research paves the way for more secure, more dependable, and more transparent autonomous driving systems.

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